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SHE CARES Mamata Banerjee with a child at a function to hand compensation to Balasore accident victims in Kolkata, June 7

WEST BENGAL

Mamata's Best Foot Forward

exercise before the 2024 Lok Sabha election, Mamata has little option but to fall back on foregrounding herself, given how a barrage of corruption allegations and accusations of high-handedness against other top functionaries have left the party image in tatters. She has past practice: jolted just a month before the 2016 assembly election by the alleged Narada scam, Mamata banked on her charisma to snag 211 out of 294 seats. The spirit behind her new tactic of patient supplication is present somewhat in the crafting of her national role too.

Mamata quietly accepted the revised date of the Opposition parties' meeting on June 23 after the Congress stated that its leaders Rahul Gandhi and Mallikarjun Kharge would not be able to attend the meet on June 12. She now clearly endorses efforts to have the Congress on board. In fact, she is reported to have had a spat with her nephew and TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee over poaching the lone Congress MLA from Murshidabad, Bayron Biswas, whose win in the Sagardighi bypoll last March with Left support had given her a mighty scare. Biswas's defection to the TMC on May 29 embarrassed Mamata. When Congress's Jairam Ramesh reacted sharply, Mamata didn't escalate matters, merely saying that the poaching happened at a local level and she was kept in the dark.

MAMATA HAS NOT CRITICISED THE CONGRESS FOR LONG AND HAS TALKED ABOUT OPPOSITION UNITY

Even as early as late March, from a protest meeting, Mamata had given a call for a united Opposition that included the Congress. Since then, the TMC has rarely badmouthed the Congress, especially top leaders like Rahul. Mamata is a votary of the plan that Opposition regional parties, while taking on the BJP individually on their respective home turfs in 2024, could support the Congress in 200 LS seats where it fights the saffron party directly. In Patna, Mamata was the consummate team player, making appropriate comments about opposition unity and even playing mediator when Congress and AAP leaders had a spat over the Delhi ordinance issue. On July 2, when the Nationalist Congress Party's Ajit Pawar joined the BJP-Sena government in Maharashtra with nine party MLAs, Mamata called up NCP supremo Sharad Pawar to express her solidarity with him.

Politically, forging an alliance with the Congress will be beneficial for TMC, given the trend of many Muslims joining the Grand Old Party, especially in districts like Birbhum, Murshidabad, Malda and the two Dinajpurs. However, the Bengal Congress unit is dead against any truck with the TMC. Congress Rajya Sabha MP Pradip Bhattacharya says, "The Congress is sincere about its intention to drive away the BJP, but the same cannot be said of Mamata." Veteran Congress leader Abdul Mannan adds, "We have told our leaders Sonia Gandhi, Mallikarjun Kharge and K.C. Venugopal that